RAMBAM'S INTRODUCTION TO HELEK: OLAM HABA & THE 13 PRINCIPLES

God Is One: The Second Principle

Rambam's Introduction to Helek, Part 9

Source: The Rambam's Introduction to Perek Helek: Principle 2, *Yichud Hashem*

Shiur: Part 9 of the series on the Rambam's Introduction to Perek Helek, given by Dayan Daniel Kada on Zoom, early December 2025

These notes are based on the transcript of the recording.

The Text

היסוד השני: יחוד השם יתברך, כלומר שנאמין שזה שהוא סיבת הכל אחד. ואיננו כאחד הזוג, ולא כאחד המין, ולא כאיש האחד שנחלק לאחדים רבים, ולא כגוף הפשוט האחד במנין שמקבל החלוק לאין תכלית. אבל השם יתברך אחד באחדות שאין כמותה אחדות. וזה היסוד השני, מורה עליו מה שנאמר: שמע ישראל ה׳ אלהינו ה׳ אחד.

"When we say **Shema** every morning and evening, we think: *God is one, not two.* **That's an element, but not all of it.** It's a far subtler idea: **a unity without parallel.**" Even **one speck of dust** divides: into halves, atoms, protons and neutrons. **Not Hashem.**

Two parts tonight: (1) what **"one"** excludes; (2) what **"a unity unlike any unity"** means.

Part 1: Five Things "One" Excludes

1. Polytheism: the enemy of Tanach

The first principle is never argued in Tanach; this one fills it. The **Golden Calf**; the cycle of the prophets: settle, **serve idols**, suffer, prophets warn.

- **Pharaoh: מי ה׳ אשר אשמע בקלו?** The Rishonim: **which god is this?** *We have many: what does yours control?*

לא יהיה לך אלהים אחרים על פני.

"**Thankfully** few struggle with this today."

2. Dualism: the enemy of the Sages

Two gods: **Zoroastrian** light and darkness. "A **convenient** answer to evil": if God is **omnipotent** (Principle 1), why evil? **Two gods!** Some **early Christian scholars** even taught that **the God of the Old Testament is darkness, of the New, light**.

The Sages built the answer into the prayers, at the very moments day and night change:

Arvit	**אשר בדברו מעריב ערבים... בורא יום ולילה, גולל אור מפני חשך**
Shacharit (the main service begins here)	**יוצר אור ובורא חשך, עושה שלום ובורא את הכל**

That's why Shacharit is ideally at *netz*, sunrise, and Arvit at nightfall: so as day and night turn over, **you don't think there's a god of each**.

a *chazan* who repeats **Modim** is silenced, **lest he seem to thank two** :**האומר מודים מודים משתקין אותו powers**.

The Gemara (Sanhedrin 39a):

A Magian told **Ameimar**: *from the waist up belongs to Hormiz, from the waist down to Ahormiz.* Ameimar: ***then why does Ahormiz let Hormiz pass water through his territory?***

"A cute story with **a deep idea**: **an omnipotent God must control everything.** Two gods means neither has full power."

The subtle dualism we all fall into

The Ramchal devoted much of his philosophy, and a whole book, ***Da'at Tevunot***, to this. **"Deep down, we're all subtle dualists. Every time we get angry, every time we sin."**

A true monotheist knows **nothing happens outside Hashem's will**: so (a) when things go wrong, **it all comes from Him**; (b) temptation is **an illusion**, since **nothing outside His will can benefit me**. **Every sin says: *I'll gain more from this than from Hashem's will*: a denial of His oneness.**

Robert: *isn't that denying God altogether, "zero" rather than "two"?*

"You could see it either way, **both bad**. **אין עוד מלבדו**: **there's no benefit outside His will.** But Tanach's enemy was **many or two**, never **zero**."

The original sin. והייתם כאלהים יודעי טוב ורע: the snake promised **benefit from what Hashem forbade**. Refusing would have **affirmed His unity**; they **denied** it. **All history rectifies this.** When Israel truly recognises *Yichud Hashem*: **the end of days**.

Why cover our eyes for Shema? The simple reason: **focus**. **The Ramchal's:** *in this world we don't see His unity; there seem to be other forces, evil and temptation. I cover my eyes and say: Hashem Echad. I believe what I can't see.* **"Hence** mezuzot **at every door,** tefillin** every morning."

Angels' names on mezuzot. The Rambam: whoever writes them inside a mezuzah has no portion in Olam HaBa. "**The whole mezuzah is *Yichud Hashem*.** You take **the very thing that declares there's nothing besides Him** and write angels on it! If you must, **on the back**, which is why we have **Shaddai** there today. **The Rambam's had nothing.**"

3. The Trinity

"Most Christians **deny** they're polytheists: **one God with three parts. For us that's heresy.**"

Halachic consequences:

- **The Letter on Martyrdom** (learned last year): one **forced to embrace Islam** need not die, **since Islam believes in one God**. **Christianity** is **arguably** *avodah zarah*, so one would have to die rather than adopt it.

- **One may enter a mosque**, **even pray there** (Rav Ovadia permits), **but not even enter a functioning church**. *(It also contradicts Principle 3, God has no body: next week.)*

- **Some Rishonim:** for **gentiles** the Trinity is **not** *avodah zarah*: *for them* it counts as belief in one God. "That has halachic ramifications."

4. Deism

God created, **transcends** the world, and **left it**. "**Probably more popular today**: since science now accepts **a beginning**, atheism can't explain the first elements, so: *a creator who then walked away.*"

Denies Principles 1 and 2: ***Yichud Hashem* means there's no reality outside Him.** If the world exists, **He is sustaining it, every moment**: the **imagined universe** that vanishes when attention slips.

Question: "the mouth of Bilaam's donkey was created at twilight of the sixth day": isn't everything set up front, God watching it unfold?

"**Absolutely not.** Whether all miracles were **built into nature in the six days** (the **Rambam**) or are **new** (the **Ramchal**: a *machloket*), **maintenance** is constant."

5. Pantheism

God is nature; nature is God: "really **a subtle form of atheism**." Deism puts God **outside** the world; pantheism **identifies** Him with it.

Spinoza, a member of the **Amsterdam** community, was **excommunicated on 27 July 1656** by the **Ma'amad**, "**with the rabbis' consent**" (it's the board that excommunicates), in the sharpest terms: ***cursed by day, cursed by night…***

London's own controversy. In **1703**, **Chacham David Nieto** of **Bevis Marks** (author of ***Mateh Dan***) preached that **God and nature are one**. Members of the board, "**more knowledgeable than the rabbi**, of course," accused him of **Spinozism**; **Joshua Zarphati** rallied people against "**the heretic rabbi, the pantheist in our midst**." It raged **over a year**. Nieto **didn't step down**: *I meant God's force runs through all nature.*

In **1705** the *parnassim* of **Sha'ar HaShamayim** asked the **Chacham Tzvi** (rabbi of Hamburg, **briefly rabbi in London**). His ruling (on Sefaria): **we must be grateful to the great *chacham David Nieto, who warned the people against the philosophers who say nature acts by itself and nothing else exists*.*** Yishar ko'ach***."*That killed the controversy.***"

> **It's easy to sink into nature**: to think the world just" .**טבעו בים סוף nature**, and also **to sink**, as in = **טבע** .in *gematria* **אלהים = 86 = טבע** ".runs by itself. **Hashem is behind nature, not nature itself**

A sixth? Panentheism

"**Briefly, 30 seconds.** There's a term for a strong **Chabad** belief: **God is *in* everything**: *everyone has a piece of God in them*; ultimately **the world is an illusion**. **That's a major problem I have with Chabad.** I think the Rambam would disagree, though it's **not explicit here**. A discussion for another time."

Part 2: "A Unity Unlike Any Unity"

The Mishneh Torah (Yesodei HaTorah 1): אלוה זה אחד הוא, ואינו שנים ולא יותר על שנים… אלא יחוד שאין יחוד אחר כמותו בעולם.

Ch. 2 (on His knowledge):

> **הקב״ה מכיר אמתו ויודע אותה כמו שהיא, ואינו יודע בדעה שהיא חוץ ממנו כמו שאנו יודעים, שאין אנו ודעתנו אחד. אבל הבורא יתברך, הוא ודעתו וחייו אחד מכל צד ומכל פינה ובכל דרכי יחוד… נמצאת אומר:**

הוא היודע, והוא הידוע, והוא הדעה עצמה, הכל אחד. ודבר זה אין כח בפה לאמרו, ולא באזן לשמעו.

He is the knower, the known and the knowledge itself, all one. The mouth can't say it; the ear can't hear it.

Reuven and his attributes. "*Reuven is clever, handsome, kind*: there's **Reuven**, who **happens** to have these. **That's not unified.** God isn't **God plus** wisdom, kindness, compassion. **It's all one.** The Ramchal calls it **פשיטות, simplicity**: **no parts, one essence.** Very hard for us to grasp, because **everything we know is composite**."

Yigdal: אחד ואין יחיד כיחודו, נעלם וגם אין סוף לאחדותו: hidden from us, endless. **Ani Ma'amin: ואין יחידות כמוהו בשום פנים**.

Then what about the Thirteen Attributes?

said "over and over" on Yom Kippur and all year. **That's God** :**ה׳ ה׳ אל רחום וחנון ארך אפים ורב חסד ואמת** **.*plus* compassion, *plus* truth. A plurality**

Negative theology

The Rambam: God has no positive attributes. Every attribute in the Torah **tells us what God is *not***, because **negations imply no plurality**.

The Torah says	It means
Strong / able (**יכול**)	**Not weak**
Compassionate	**Not hard-hearted**
Eternal	**Not caused**
Wise / knowing (**יודע**)	**Not ignorant**
Willing (**רוצה**)	**Not indifferent**

Moreh 1:58: דע שתאור האל בשלילות הוא התאור הנכון: **describing God by negation is the correct description.** Positive attributes imply **composition and deficiency**; negations **guide the mind** without them.

"**It changes your whole perspective on the Torah.** On Yom Kippur, think ***El Rachum veChanun***, that's fine. **But theologically, His unity means complete simplicity.**"

Why the Ramchal puts everything on *Yichud Hashem*

We can't grasp any positive attribute: that would mean **grasping God Himself**. **We *can negate. And negating means: no other force. So the only thing we can truly understand of God is that He is one, and the purpose of life is to reveal Yichud Hashem***.

Pesachim 50a:

Isn't He one now? **Not like this world is the world** .(said daily in **Aleinu**) **ביום ההוא יהיה ה׳ אחד ושמו אחד** *I don't see how it's good;* :**ברוך דיין האמת** ,for bad ;**הטוב והמטיב to come.** Here, for good news we say **.***Hashem is the true judge.* **In the world to come it will all be *Hatov veHameitiv***

"***Yichud Hashem* means believing, philosophically if not practically, that even the bad is good, since it all comes from one source. One day we'll see it. Now we cover our eyes.**"

A caution about the *Sefirot*

The Rivash (Rav Yitzchak bar Sheshet, 14th century, "quoted in halachah everywhere") wrote of a great rabbi who **prayed one prayer to one *sefirah, another to another, each blessing of the Amidah aimed at a sefirah. To us, this is very strange; it looks like dualism.* A philosopher mocked:*** the Christians believe in three, the Kabbalists in ten.***

In **Zaragoza** the Rivash asked his friend **Don Yosef ibn Shoshan**, a great Talmudist, Kabbalist and *tzaddik*. *God forbid, we pray only to the One. As with a king: for justice you go to the judge, for money to the treasury.* "**Like one prime minister** with a Foreign Office, Home Office, Treasury." **The Rivash:** *very nice, but better to pray without all of this***.

Never imagine parts of Hashem. "As it was explained to me years ago: **one sunlight** through **different media** comes out **different colours**. **That's the *sefirot*: the same light of God through different media.**"

Summary

1. **"Hashem is one" excludes:**
2. **polytheism** (Tanach's enemy; *who is Hashem?*);
3. **dualism** (the Sages', answered in **יוצר אור ובורא חשך**; **Modim** twice; **Hormiz and Ahormiz**), including the **subtle dualism of every sin** (Ramchal): the **original sin**, **eyes covered at Shema**, no **angels in mezuzot**;
4. **the Trinity** (Islam vs Christianity; mosque vs church);
5. **deism** (He sustains every moment);
6. **pantheism** (**Spinoza**; **Nieto** vindicated by the **Chacham Tzvi**; **טבע = אלהים**).

(And **panentheism**, a Chabad view the Rabbi rejects; for another time.)

2. **"A unity unlike any unity"**: **knower, known and knowledge are one**: **simplicity, no parts**.

3. So **no positive attributes**: **every attribute is a negation** (Moreh 1:58). The **Thirteen Attributes** say what He is **not**.

4. **The only thing we can grasp is His oneness**: the **Ramchal**'s key to everything. **In the world to come, all is *Hatov veHameitiv*.**

5. **Sefirot** are **one light through different media**, never parts of God (the **Rivash**).

Coming Up

Principle 3: Hashem has no body. "The next principles will be easier and quicker. **The first two were the big ones.**"

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